‘I’ll call you straight back.’

The first person I spoke to was Gary Neville. Without even thinking about it, his reaction was:

‘You’ve got to tell the manager. Go and see Kevin.’

I made my way through the hotel to his room. I knocked on the door and went in. I’m sure Kevin could see for himself something was wrong. I was shaking; I felt sick. I could hardly find the breath for it but I told him what had happened. The first thing Kevin did was let me know he understood what I felt like which, when you’ve lost control like I had, is the first thing you need to hear.

‘David, I’ve been in a situation like this. When I was playing in Germany, me and my wife had death threats made against us. I know this is horrible. We need to go to where your wife and son are. We’ll go together. We’ll sort this out.’

It was ten o’clock at night by now. In minutes, we were outside the hotel in a car—me, Kevin and Ray Whitworth, England’s team security officer—and I was calling Victoria to tell her we were on our way. We drove to Tony and Jackie’s. As soon as we walked in, although he’d never met Victoria or her parents, Kevin took control of the situation. He knew me and could see for himself the state Victoria was in: we needed him to be calm and know the right thing to do.

‘The best place to be is our hotel. We’ve got the whole place booked to ourselves. We’ve our own security. Nobody’s getting in. Pack a bag. Get Brooklyn. David and I will go back now, sort the rooms out, and we’ll meet you there as soon as you’re ready.’

Kevin had been just brilliant when we needed him most. He’d done it all without even thinking twice about it, even though there was a game the following afternoon. Never mind his qualities as a manager. This was Kevin doing his best for us just because he could, not because he felt he had to. He would have done what he did, though, for any of the England players. In fact I really believe that, if Kevin had found himself in those same circumstances and able to help, he’d have done what he did for anybody at all. He’s a great man.

Victoria and Brooklyn slept in my room. The next morning, all Kevin was concerned about was what I felt I should do.